

Intro to the Jamictionary

Dear reader,

This is a short intro to the "Jamictionary" : a compilation of music scores mixing some of the most frequently danced tunes in the European Balfolk festivals and some of the most frequently danced tunes in regional folk scenes. This database is designed to be used in multiple ways :

- As a leadsheet for the live performance in a jam session.
- As a collaborative database for dance music.
- As a music reading and training tool.
- As an enabler of transformation in the instrument hierarchy of jam sessions.
- As a discussion starter on how broken is the concept of traditional music databases.

There are currently 2 versions of the database : v.1 is named "Jamicionario" and the v.2 is named "Jamictionary". Only V.2 will remain after the transition period.

- V.1 : A Portugal-based Muscores and PDF-file database, lasting from 2022 to 26. If you're reading this introduction, V1 is the database next to it.
- V.2 : A International website in English language, starting on 2026.

What's inside :

V.1 :

- The goal of the "Jamicionário" is twofold :
 - To achieve a minimum common repertoire in the Balfolk jam sessions throughout Portugal.
 - To raise the local cultural and performance bar by introducing an organised map of the very extensive European folk and neo-folk dance music.
- It follows the blueprint of jazz's reference jam session book, "The Real Book." It then abandons the binding to exist as a shared folder on the internet that you can save on your computer. Each tune has two files: a PDF file and a MuseScore file. MuseScore is a software that allows you to edit the tunes, so you can create multiple versions of one score. There are no standards for the tunes : the melodies and chords I've provided are only suggestions. The software opens the door for the music jam be coordinated by any instrument as it makes real-time transposition of any music a possibility.

V.2 :

- The goal of the Jamictionary will be threefold :
 - To provide an central database into European trad. and neo.trad dance music focused on performance and jam sessioning.
 - To achieve a minimum common repertoire in the Balfolk jam sessions throughout Europe.
 - To raise the cultural and performance bar by introducing an organised map of the very extensive European folk and neo-folk dance music.
- It will follow the blueprint of Irish trad. music reference website, thesession.org. The website is now under development and will develop the architecture of "thesession" website by adapting to the complexities of music genres of European music and the challenges they present to adapt into the format of jam sessions.

How it is organised

The database owes its name (the amalgamation of Jam and Dictionary) to the organisation of the content. It is divided into 2 main categories :

- Dance families (mazurka, waltz, bourrée, etc.), organised in alphabetical order. Most tunes belong to this category. They are often further organised into subcategories (i.e., the two-time and the tree-time bourrée).
- Singles. This exceptional category incorporates the tunes that are specific to a single dance (Mardi Gras, Alunelul, Rumelaj, etc.). This separation between dance families and singles already exists in traditional Irish folk music, and they refer to "singles" as "set dances." The singles are not reorganised into subcategories.

Let's jam!

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